11

Mass Media in the 20th Century



Figure 11.1

In today's world, you and your family have many ways and many devices to receive news from remote corners of the world. You also have many ways and many gadgets to convey your thoughts and views to people living across the world from the comfort of your home. These devices that carry our messages to other people and that bring news from other people to us are called communication or media devices.

Can you make a list of all the methods by which you receive news, views and messages?

Apart from these communication media, there are many other ways in which we exchange news and views with each other in our daily life – for example, by talking, writing, shouting, drawing, gesturing, sign language, beating a drum etc. Humans were exchanging views and messages in different ways even before the invention of modern communication media.

You learned about the invention of the printing press and the impact it made on people's lives during the Renaissance period. After the industrial revolution, many new machines were invented that made it easy to communicate ideas and exchange news rapidly and easily. Many of these communication

devices and methods - such as the gramophone, telegraph, telephone, wireless, typewriter, movies, camera, etc - were invented and developed in the latter half of the 19th century. They made it easy to convey ideas and messages rapidly to large numbers of people living in faraway places. Naturally, these inventions had a profound effect on society and the lives of people living in the 20th century.

Over the last 150 years, communication media have made it possible for people to immediately know of any incident occurring in any corner of the world. But the different kinds of communication media tend to convey similar news and views about the incident so people share and experience similar information about the incident. At the same time, the media also carry advertisements of industrial products and consumer goods. This happens on global scale. So communication media now reach the same news, same views and same advertisements at the same time to people of different cultures and languages living in different countries across the globe. Thus, communication media have been transformed into mass media today has the power to influence and control the thinking and lifestyles of vast populations. In this lesson we shall try to understand various aspects of this development.

What are communication media?

Communication means to send or receive anything from one place to another. But we generally use the word communication in the context of conveying an idea or message from one place to another or from one person to another. Newspapers and letters are examples of communication media. A letter is written to a particular person or persons who are its recipients and readers while a newspaper or magazine is published for a wider readership. Communication media that reach ideas and messages to a wide audience are known as mass communication media or mass media.

11.1 Print media

The invention of printing led to a sharp rise in the number of literate people and printed material in Europe. Many new institutions such as libraries and book fairs came into existence in the 19th century as more and more printed material became available. Steam engines began powering printing presses in Europe from 1814 and colour printing presses were built from 1837. By the dawn of the 20th century, printing presses were powered by electricity. These developments reduced the cost of printing, so it became possible to print larger quantities of books and magazines.

Newspapers: Two types of newspapers were printed in America and Britain at the beginning of the 19th century. One type specialised in publishing commercial news for traders and merchants while the other type was devoted to popularising the ideologies of political parties. There was also a third type of tabloid newspaper that was cheap and published news of interest to the working class. This tabloid newspaper was called the penny press or farthings magazine. Its content was mostly crime reports and human interest stories.

Newspapers were a good vehicle for informing people about manufactured products and goods. Advertisements of these products led to a rise in consumption and mass production of goods. Thus, advertising proved to be an additional source of revenue for newspapers in the 19th century. In fact, advertisements became their main revenue earning source by the early decades of the 20th century when newspapers began to be illustrated with photographs. Illustrated advertisements had a greater influence in moulding people's opinions.

When newspapers first began to be circulated in Britain in the 19th century, the country was going through a period of political upheavals. The working class was demanding greater participation in democratic elections, which were limited to the upper classes in those days. Seeing the growing influence of newspapers, the government began imposing stiff restrictions on them to control the anti-government propaganda. Newspapers were censored and prohibited from publishing news reports that were unfavourable to the government. A tax – called the stamp tax – was also imposed on them to raise their prices and ensure they were no longer within the reach of the common people. But the stamp tax had the opposite effect. Small printing presses began printing illegal newspapers that became very popular among the people.



Figure 11.2: Cartoon

People opposed the stamp tax because they saw it as a tax on knowledge, eventually forcing the government to withdraw the tax in 1858. This step ushered in the golden age of newspapers. But this was also the age when publishing newspapers became expensive. They required heavy investments and revenue from advertising to survive. Only the large corporations had the money to invest and advertise so the newspapers soon came under the control of the big capitalist houses. They not only gave advertisements to the newspapers but also began controlling the kind of news and views they published. These large publishing houses also began publishing newspapers in large numbers and distributing them in every region and state. By 1930, in Britain, four such large publishing empires controlled almost half of all the newspapers and magazines that were published. Their owners came to be known as press barons.

The changes in the ownership of publication houses in the 20th century also led to changes in the role and influence of newspapers. Apart from publishing news and advertisements, they began to propagate different ideologies. This trend was particularly noticeable during the First World War when newspapers in Britain and Germany whipped up public sentiment for the war effort and hatred for the enemy in their respective countries. The newspapers published news to generate ultra-nationalistic feelings among the people and encourage them to enlist in the army.

In literate countries like America and Britain, most men and women read newspapers. For example, in 1980, 76 percent of British males and 62 percent of females read newspapers. By the end of the 1980s electronic media like television developed rapidly, replacing newspapers as the primary medium for dispensing news. As a result, the print media began to face a crisis situation.

English newspapers were published in India after the British established their colonial regime. The first newspapers were published in Calcutta, Madras (Chennai) and Bombay (Mumbai) between 1780 and 1792. The first Indian language publication was *Digdarshan*, a Bengali magazine published by Marshman from Serampore in Bengal in 1818. Raja Ram Mohan Roy published the first Persian newspaper *Mirat-ul-Akhbar* in 1822. Subsequently, newspapers in regional languages began to be published in different states. Many of the important English daily newspapers that began publication



Figure 11.3: Indian newspapers and television channels

between 1860 and 1890 still exist today. Examples include the *Times of India*, *Statesman* and *The Hindu*. In 1881, Lokmanya Tilak began publishing the famous Marathi nationalist magazine *Kesari*.

The colonial government did seek to control newspapers but there was always strong opposition to press censorship so the state could never exercise total control over the media. The first law to govern the press was passed in 1799. It required the publisher to declare his name and address so that the government could conduct enquiries whenever required and also get the approval of the government censor before publishing the newspaper. Another law was passed in 1878 to control Indian language publications. It required the publisher to file a declaration that he would not publish any anti-government news or news that could disturb the peace. The publisher had to deposit a large sum of money with the district magistrate, which could be confiscated if he did not comply with the law. Indian publishers protested strongly against this law, leading to its withdrawal in 1881. But a similar law was passed in 1910, which was, in turn, withdrawn in 1922 and again re-implemented in 1931. The history of press laws, thus, shows that the Indian middle class strongly opposed censorship laws and agitated for their withdrawal.

India, too, has its press barons and powerful publishing houses. The prominent among them are the Kasturi Iyyengar family of *The Hindu*, the Sahu Jain family of the *Times of India* and *Navbharat Times*, the Goenka family of the *Indian Express* and *Jansatta*, the K.K. Birla family of the *Hindustan Times* and the Aroon Purie family of the *India Today* group. The first four of these publishing houses were founded before independence. Apart from these five, there are many publishing houses at the regional level that publish newspapers and magazines in Hindi and other Indian languages.

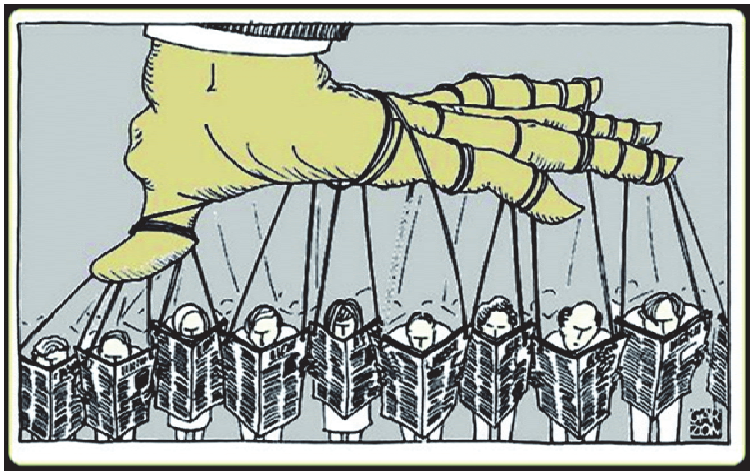


Figure 11.4: A cartoon by Alfedo Garzon. What is being said in this cartoon?

Does your school subscribe to any newspapers or magazines? Which magazines do people in your neighbourhood read? Who publishes these magazines?

Why do some influential families gain control of publications? What impact do you think this has on society and politics in the country?

Can advertisers also influence publications? How?

In countries like India, the biggest advertisers are the government. What impact do you think this could have on publications?

11.2 Electronic media

Telegraph: The invention of telegraphy by Samuel Morse in 1837 made it possible to convey information instantaneously by electrical signals via transmission lines. Telegraph machines helped newspapers gain access to more news. Time is the most important element in collecting news. For example, a newspaper that publishes the latest political news or the rise and fall of cotton prices in the market is more likely to sell in larger numbers. The rapid dissemination of information via telegraphy leads to a levelling of prices in the market. Information, thus, becomes a crucial input for industrialists and traders.

What kind of information is a resource? Discuss in class. Can you give some examples?

Would you consider the information that gives you happiness a resource? Give reasons, whether for or against the proposition.

Find out from your elders how telegrams and telegraphy were used and whether they are still in use.

Telephone: Graham Bell invented the telephone in 1876-77. The device allows us to talk with each other via wire even if we are hundreds of miles apart. Within a few years of its invention, telephony was widely used across the world including India. Many large companies began laying a network of transmission lines and manufacturing the equipment to open voice communications on a global scale.

Radio: Wireless radio allows voice communication without a network of transmission lines. Such wireless communication via radio waves made it easier to broadcast information across the world. Guglielmo Marconi of Italy made history when he first established wireless transmission across the Atlantic Ocean in 1901. Prior to this, communication was only possible through the network of transmission lines. Initially, radio communication was used only by the military and ships on the high seas. But radio developed into a mass communication medium after 1920.

The number of radio broadcasting stations in America grew rapidly after the end of the First World War. Many of these were illegal broadcasting stations running without a licence from the government. By 1930, radio broadcasting covered 40 percent of American homes. Most radio stations initially broadcast only music programmes but later began adding plays, comedies, discussions and educational programmes to their broadcasting schedules. During the Second World War, radio became the main channel to broadcast news about the war and air programmes to generate support for the war effort. Radio also became a powerful instrument for political and election propaganda during this period.

Radio broadcasting spread to other industrial countries after 1920, with the number of radio stations growing in France, Belgium, Germany, Russia and Italy. In India, All India Radio (Akashvani) began public broadcasting in 1930. The main purpose and duty of radio broadcasting was seen as conveying news and information to the people, educating them and providing entertainment to them.

Film: The Lumiere brothers screened the world's first moving pictures in 1895. In those days, the movies were silent – they did not have sound or voices. So the dialogues in the film were written as sub-titles. This medium became so influential and popular that many countries across the world began producing films and building countless theatres to screen them. In India, the first film called *Raja Harishchandra* was produced by Dadasaheb Phalke in 1913.

Making films is expensive and there is no guarantee that they will recover their investment after being screened to the public. That is why film production also began to attract the wealthy capitalists who could invest in their production. But these capitalists began controlling the content of films and the social and political ideas they propagated. And like newspapers and magazines, films, too, became a medium for advertising consumer goods and propagating consumer lifestyles. Given the high cost of production, films began to be produced in a few select centres around the world. In India, Bombay (Mumbai) and Madras (Chennai) are among the main film production centres. Most of the films screened in Britain, America and many other countries across the world are produced in Hollywood. This centralisation of culture is now giving rise to fears of cultural imperialism.

Films can be seen as a mirror of the times. During the Second World War, the majority of films produced in Hollywood focused on patriotism and extolling the virtues of the nation. After the war, many films based on social issues such as racial segregation, colour prejudice and antisemitism began to be made for the first time. This stream was evident even during the Cold War era, with the characters in films reflecting national or ethnic stereotypes. For example, racial prejudices and international tensions existing during the era of the Cold War were clearly reflected in the James Bond films made during that period. In India, too, films made in different eras reflected the social and political life of their times.

Before the invention of cinema, what were the main forms of entertainment? What differences and similarities do you see between these forms of entertainment and films?

Television: After the Second World War, a new medium of communication began to take the place of radio. A Scottish engineer named John Logie Baird demonstrated this electronic audio-visual communication medium for the first time in the decade of the 1920s. It came to be known as television or TV. This was a major invention in the field of broadcast communication. Like film, television, too, can be viewed by lakhs of people. But television is different from film. People can view television in their homes while doing their daily work, like they used to listen to the radio earlier. Radio and television, thus, became part of the daily life of people. Television, in fact, soon began to dominate people's lives with its news, views and images.

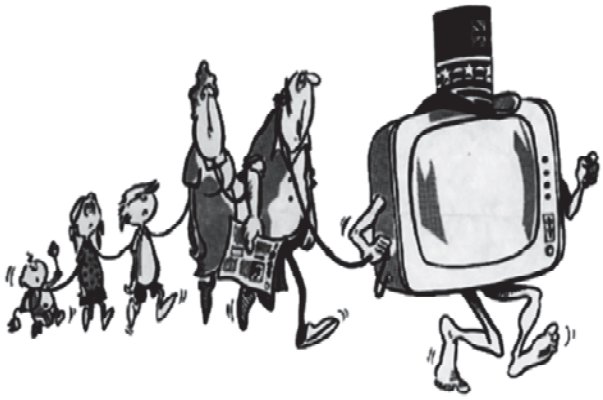


Figure 11.5: The slaves of media



Figure 11.6: Television during the American presidential election

Surveys show that people in developed countries like Britain and the United States are enslaved by television, watching it passively during their leisure time. On average, individuals in these countries, whether children below 4 years of age or retired people, spend three to four hours daily watching television. Where earlier they used to go out to meet friends, go for a stroll or do some activity at home, they now spend their time reclined on their sofas watching TV. This change in lifestyle has had two important repercussions. First, where people would earlier discuss issues and incidents, they now tend to see everything as entertainment. People who read newspapers and magazines are said to be more likely to think and discuss issues than people who view the same issues on TV. Second, people now spend less time with each other because of their TV viewing. As a result, social interaction is becoming more limited while social relationships are also being diluted.

TV and elections

The first presidential debate to be broadcast on TV was between the presidential candidates Richard Nixon and John F. Kennedy in the US elections in September 1960. The debate had a viewership of around seven crore people. Kennedy won the election. A survey conducted after the election revealed that those who had listened to the debate on radio felt that Nixon would emerge the victor while those who watched the television debate felt the opposite. The TV broadcast won the young and charismatic Kennedy more votes than the tired and haggard-looking (but more experienced) Nixon.



Figure 11.7: A middle class family watching the Nixon-Kennedy presidential debate on TV in their living room

The election result revealed the power of television to sway public opinion. In the 20th century, TV has become a potent medium for people to establish the social and political image and credentials. But TV has also shown that it is not enough for a person to be politically and socially capable; he or she must also look more photogenic and presentable.

While TV and radio broadcasting was done by private companies in America, it was controlled by the government in Europe, India and other countries. In Britain, the government established the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) in 1926. Its operational expenses were borne out of the taxes collected from radio and TV subscribers. In 1950, private companies were allowed to enter the field of broadcasting in Britain. In India, too, the government's monopoly over broadcasting continued until 1990, with Akashvani being the sole broadcaster, after which private channels were granted permission to broadcast.

As the number of television sets grew across the world, there was a corresponding fall in the number of cinema theatres screening films. By the decade of the 1960s, 5.2 crore American homes had television, the number increasing to 28.5 crore homes by 2006. In India, Akashvani began TV broadcasting in 1965. By 2007, around 12 crore Indian households had TV. During this period, many improvements took place in the techniques of broadcasting (antenna, cable, satellite box etc).

In 1975, only a few cities in India had television, with the daily broadcasts limited to a few hours of news bulletins and other programmes. National broadcasting began in 1982, with Doordarshan being the monopoly TV channel. Its primary objective was to bring about social change through its programmes on national integration, agriculture, literacy, education, health and social welfare. At the same time, it broadcast entertainment serials such as *Hum Log* and *Buniyaad* to foster a sense of nationalism, of unity in diversity, among the people. Doordarshan also broadcast epics from the Hindu *Puranas* such as *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata* based on the Hindu *Puranas*. These epics attracted a viewership of lakhs of people who would remain glued to their television sets when the episodes were broadcast. These serials established global viewership records.

As a result, the number of people buying TV sets kept growing in the decade of the 1980s. During this period, Doordarshan also began regional broadcasts. The decade of the 1990s saw the introduction of commercial and private channels like Star TV, Zee TV, Sun TV, CNN etc. Unlike Doordarshan, the primary aim of these private channels is to earn a profit. There is intense competition among them for viewership.

Commercial television reached advertisements of consumer and industrial goods to vast numbers of people, influencing their buying decisions and their lifestyle choices. The intense competition for viewership led the channels to explore new themes and programming. As a result, there was a sharp increase in entertainment programming and television advertising. Many channels began producing soap operas featuring conflicts arising in Indian families as a result of the clash between traditional paternalistic attitudes and emerging modern values. The majority of characters in these family dramas were women. Companies also began featuring film stars and famous personalities in advertisements for their products and services. By the closing decades of the 20th century, entertainment began taking the form of a mass technology in India.

Which channels are popular in your home and among your neighbours? Among these, which are private channels and which are government channels?

If news is broadcast only by government channels, what impact would it have on society?

Which channel do you consider to be the most reliable for news broadcasts?

Which channel has the most crime, sex and violence?

Which channel do you think has the best entertainment?

Advertisements give rise to new lifestyle aspirations among viewers. How reliable are the claims made in advertisements? Discuss in class.

11.3 Internet and digital media – new age media

The computer has made it possible to digitise all kinds of information in numerical code, whether it is words, sound, images or audio-visual films. This makes it possible to easily and rapidly transmit any kind of information from one place to another. Artificial satellites that orbit the earth have played an important part in simplifying the process and allowing information to be transmitted on a global scale. Satellite transmission is, indeed, a revolutionary development in human history. People can now not only see, hear and read information but also change it. This has led to the development of interactive media such as video games. Digital technology has also unified the computer, phone and television in devices like the mobile smartphone. One consequence of this unification is that people are no longer mute spectators but active participants. They can choose what they want to see or read, what information they want to access and when they would like to access it. They can also broadcast their views and images. All this has been made possible by the internet, which is part of the digital revolution. The internet has played the role of bringing computers and mobiles together on a single platform globally. After 1990, internet use spread like wildfire.

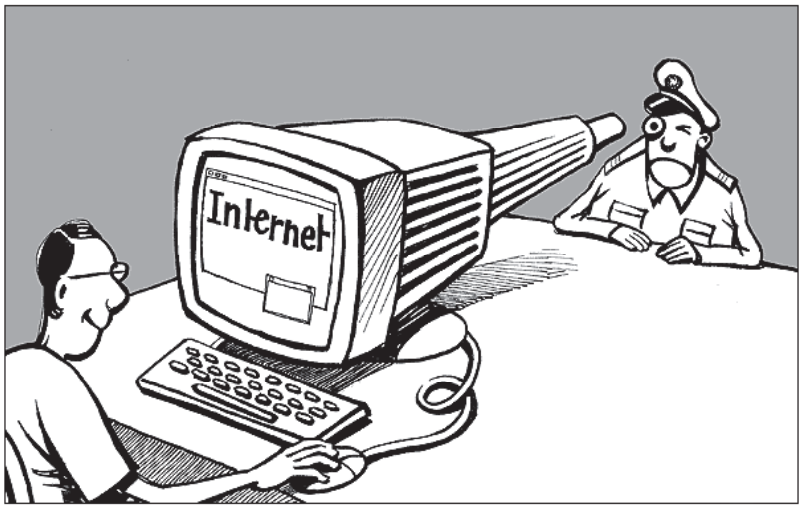


Figure 11.8 What is this cartoon saying about how the internet is endangering the freedom of the individual

Every individual can now be connected to the world by the internet and the digital revolution. They can get information, access entertainment resources and contact people across the world. They are not just a source of information and entertainment but a platform for economic and commercial activities such as trade - buying and selling - banking, etc. Companies can instantly invest or withdraw crores of rupees from any country in any corner of the world. Digital resources have, thus, become a means of bringing people together, establishing communication between them and allowing them to interact on a global scale. They are a medium for dialogue and interaction between people who have never met.

In today's world, the internet has been extensively used in people's movements. It also helps private companies and governments to keep a tab on people's activities. Such information has the potential for misuse. Social scientists continue to study and assess the internet's powerful worldwide impact.

Have you ever used the internet? Tell the class about your experience of using the internet.

Have you made a friend or struck up a conversation with a person you do not know on the internet? Tell the class about it.

You might have heard or read about globalisation. What links do you see between globalisation and the development of communication media?

Mass media, critical thinking and entertainment

Democracy in any country depends on the level of public discourse. The health of democracy depends on the extent to which people participate in public dialogue and exchange views. Some experts say that mass media centralises public discourse and treats the exchange of views as entertainment. Earlier, people discussed issues in small groups so their level of participation was high and the views they exchanged was more diversified. But mass media mediated discussions take place between fewer people and are watched by the large masses of people who do not get the opportunity to put forward their views and opinions. Thus, people expect entertainment rather than analysis from such programmes. Media channels encourage them to think in a particular way, which reflects the views of the channel owners

One example of how mass media influenced mass thinking was the Iraq war. The US and Britain claimed that Iraqi president Saddam Hussein was preparing weapons of mass destruction and if he wasn't stopped, the entire world would be endangered. This claim had no real basis in fact but it was nevertheless widely propagated by the American media. As a result of this mass propaganda, America invaded Iraq in 2003 and executed Saddam Hussein. Around 150,000 to 6,00,000 people were killed and an entire country was ruined. But, despite extensive searches by the American army, no hoard of weapons of mass destruction were found.

The media was a key participant in the war, broadcasting every detail directly into people's homes. It was even said that the American and Iraqi presidents obtained the latest updates on the war from the TV broadcasts. The war also advertised the use of new weapons of war, which proved to be highly profitable for American arms manufacturers. The end result was that the media companies and arms manufacturers made huge profits by turning the war into a spectacle that entertained people.



Figure 11.9: Three images of the Iraq war broadcast by an American news channel

EXERCISES

1. Identify the incorrect statements from among the following and rectify them:
   a) Film is a mass medium.
   b) The railways are a mass medium
   c) Radio was initially used for military communication.
   d) In America, the government broadcasts radio and television.
   e) A laptop or computer is needed to use the internet.

2. Write brief answers to the following questions:
   a) What is the difference between a normal communication medium and mass media?
   b) Give four major examples of electronic media.
   c) Give the names of four prominent newspapers and magazines sold in your state.
   d) Outline the main differences between the print medium and digital medium.
   e) How was the mobile phone used in democratic revolutions? Give some examples.

3. What similarities and differences do you see between the print medium and TV? Which medium do you think has greater potential for influencing thinking and analysis?
4. Analyse the use of the mobile phone as a communication medium for providing information, serving as a platform for dialogue, entertainment, influencing people's thinking and aspirations, allowing government to keep an eye on people.
5. A democratic constitution gives people the freedom to think and express themselves. How ethical is it for governments to control and censor communication media?
6. Why does mass media come under the control of big corporations or publishing houses? What kinds of media can be independent of such control?
7. How far is it correct to say that we get only the information and news that big corporations or governments want to give us and that we are prevented from knowing or understanding information that is in our interest?
8. What is the role of advertisements in modern mass media?
9. Which communication media are in danger of disappearing today? Which media have replaced them? Give some examples.
10. What kinds of mass media are used in elections? Do you think this increases the chances of people with money or glamour stand a better chance of winning the elections?

PROJECT WORK

1. Which newspapers and magazines do you read? Read their editorials for a full week to understand their viewpoint and thinking. Discuss the viewpoints of these publications on contemporary issues in class.
2. How many minutes of advertising are there in your favourite TV programmes? How many advertisements are shown and what was the duration of the actual programme? Quantify your results and make a poster exhibition. All the students in the class should then prepare a consolidated poster exhibition.
3. What are the traditional communication and entertainment forms in your village or town? What is their situation today? Prepare a report.

-: वाहन चलाते समय वाहन में रखे जाने वाले महत्वपूर्ण दस्तावेज :-

चालक अनुज्ञा पत्र :- वाहन चलाते समय चालक को वैद्य अनुज्ञा पत्र (ड्रायविंग लायसेंस) साथ रखना अनिवार्य होता है।



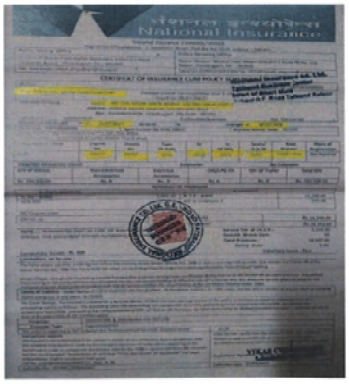
पंजीयन प्रमाण- पत्र :- सभी प्रकार के डीजल/पेट्रोल/इलेक्ट्रिक पावर से चलने वाले वाहनों के लिए परिवहन विभाग द्वारा जारी पंजीयन प्रमाण-पत्र (रजिस्ट्रेशन सर्टिफिकेट) रखना आवश्यक होता है।



फिटनेस प्रमाण-पत्र :- व्यवसायिक प्रयोग में आने वाले वाहनों के सभी कलपुर्जों को दुरूस्त रखना अतिआवश्यक है। अतः ऐसे वाहनों को फिटनेस प्रमाण-पत्र की आवश्यकता होती है।



बीमा प्रमाण-पत्र :- सभी प्रकार के डीजल/पेट्रोल/इलेक्ट्रिक पावर से चलने वाले वाहनों के लिए बीमा प्रमाण-पत्र (इंश्योरेंस सर्टिफिकेट) रखना आवश्यक होता है।



प्रदूषण प्रमाण-पत्र :- डीजल/पेट्रोल चलित वाहनों के लिए कार्बन उत्सर्जन को नियंत्रित रखने तथा पर्यावरण को बनाये रखने हेतु पदूषण नियंत्रण प्रमाण-पत्र रखना आवश्यक होता है।

